

everybody is making it out to be. In fact, these promoters are trying to cover their own follies by blaming me,' he said.

I knew he was not entirely wrong. But I loved to annoy him, and decided to prod further.

'I heard one of the promoters has sworn to make you cover your positions at twice the price you have short-sold,' I said.

'Is it? Which of them? Let them try, I am waiting. *Saale @#**\$,* do you hear any of them ever complaining to SEBI whenever their stocks rise to crazy levels? They never say that bull operators are ramping up their stock prices and that retail investors could get hurt if they buy the shares at those exorbitant prices. But the moment their stock prices fall, they claim that bears are destroying shareholder wealth. Reminds me of a primary school classroom where a student says: "Teacher, this boy is beating me."

'As for the brokerage firm promoter, his behaviour is the most appalling. A couple of years ago when I was trading through his firm and hammering other companies' stocks, he never protested even once that I was destroying shareholder value. Obviously, why would he bother when he was earning good commissions from me? But when I feel his company's stock is fair game, he goes whining to SEBI.

'I tell you, Lala, I have been at the receiving end so many times when I have been short on stocks. The promoters gang up with bull operators and manipulate the prices higher. Had they not done that, the prices would have followed their natural course and I would have made good money. But do I complain to SEBI about the promoters' misdeeds? No, I don't. I take my medicine like a man, and I don't understand why they can't do the same.'

JC had a point, but the promoters too had their reasons for being furious with him. My friends in the market told me JC had a knack for identifying companies where the promoters had pledged the most shares to raise money, and then would start hammering their stocks.

In March 2008, shares of Chennai-based Orchid Chemicals and Pharmaceuticals plunged 39 per cent in a single trading session as two NBFCs liquidated the shares that promoter Raghavendra Rao had pledged with them. The stock first started to weaken when the US investment bank Bear Sterns, which was grappling with its own problems in the wake of the